FEELING FOREIGN IN THE ‘BURBS:

DIFFERING RECEPTIONS OF LIBERIAN AND SOMALI IMMIGRANTS IN BROOKLYN CENTER/PARK

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TRiO
DONALD E. MCNAIR POST-BACCALAUREATE ACHIEVEMENT PROGRAM

OVERVIEW

- Immigrants in increasing numbers are relocating from the core cities into suburban residential areas. In recent decades immigrant groups are settling directly into suburbia, bypassing the initial move from their mother countries into inner city ethic enclaves (Dawkins 2009, pp. 82).
- Increased availability of low-skill jobs in the suburbs creates a shift in the residential patterns of immigrants suggesting an important relationship between economic need and place of residency (Greene 1997, pp.180).
- Brooklyn Center and Brooklyn Park have experienced large demographic shifts in the past decade that show a decrease in white residents and a dramatic increase in their immigrant population.
- While the rise of diversity in these cities is celebrated, concern over the effects of minorities on crime rates, housing prices, and quality of life are prevalent.
- A sizable portion of the foreign born in these communities are Somali and Liberian refugees. Both have come to Minnesota seeking protection from civil conflict in their homelands. The social reception of these immigrants differs.
- This case study provides preliminary observations of how these two refugee communities have been constructed as either “good” or “bad” and how these perceptions affect their adjustment in the suburbs.
- This study discusses the educational and residential segregation of suburban school districts and its consequences on immigrant minorities’ access to quality instruction.

METHODOLOGY

Data collected for this research comes from three sources

1. Participant observation was conducted in the Liberian and Somali owned food/clothing markets of Brooklyn Center and Brooklyn Park .
2. Policy reports on education, health, and immigration were used to observe how the Liberian and Somali communities are being framed.
3. Mainstream newspapers like the Star Tribune and the Pioneer Press, as well as ethnic newspapers, electronic news sites, and housing websites were used to understand how refugees are framed in the media.

“Somali society is based on violence, and Somali immigrants retain their violent ways. Because Somalis are classified as “black” in police statistics, there is no way to separate Somali crime from black crime in general. Nonetheless, evidence exists for a pattern of major Somali crime on a city-wide scale in Minneapolis.” -Duncan Hengest (White America Article)

Photos are from: gutcheckpolitics.com and mandingonations.com

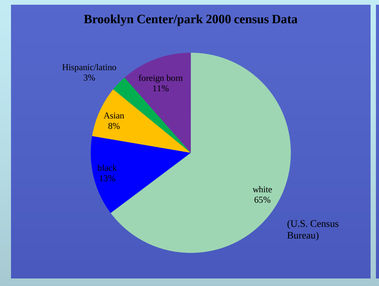
RESULTS

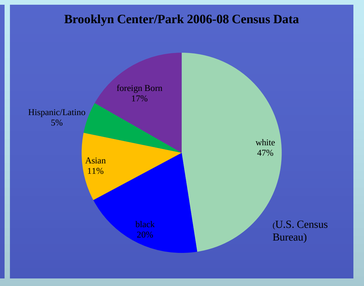
Media Portrayal and Perceived Challenges

- Coverage of Somalis dominated by terrorism, gang violence, Somali pirates, alleged suicide bombings, and missing Somali boys.
- Coverage of Liberians is dominated by the civil war in their homeland and deportation after their temporary protection status expires.
- While Liberians are often framed as deserving, hard working, Somalis are framed as a social problem.
- Liberians receive more media sympathy than Somalis.
- Coverage emphasizes how Liberians have earned the right to stay in the U.S. by contributing economically.
- Refugees have contributed to a fall in income and rise in poverty.
- Rise of low income minorities is burdensome because they require more services.
- Fear of property values dropping and crime rates increasing
- Immigrants negatively affect Minnesota’s quality of life

Available Social Services

- Brooklyn Center immigrants have access to 13 different programs within 5 miles of the city, 5 of which are located in the city.
- Brooklyn Park immigrants have access to 10 different programs within five miles of the city, 2 of which are located in the city.
- No program offers transportation but all are located on a city bus line.
- Center for Victims of Torture works with Liberian refugees suffering from war trauma and assists them in finding treatment.
- The Brian Cole Community Center, African Development Center, The East African Women’s Center, and the Confederation of Somali Community in Minnesota are a few of the many organizations in the twin cities that serve Somalis.





Residential and School Segregation

- Increase of racial diversity has not meant better racial integration.
- The Osseo school district is one of the most segregated in the suburbs.
- Minority students are concentrated in few schools and districts.
- Independent School District 286 in Brooklyn Center is the most diverse, with the most economically deprived population, and some of the worst performing schools.

Current problems facing Somali and Liberian Immigrants

- Language Barrier is greatest obstacle to adjustment and employment access for all refugees.
- African refugees who speak little English face greater hostility.
- Limited knowledge of their rights makes immigrants vulnerable to exploitation.
- Muslim Africans face harsher discrimination because of their religion.
- Cultural misunderstanding continues to cause tension and violence.
- Refugees feel a lack of belonging and trust outside of their communities.



DISCUSSION

- In Brooklyn Center and Brooklyn Park, the presence of immigrants is not as pronounced as it is in Minneapolis and St. Paul because they are much more dispersed in the suburbs.
- Liberians speak English and therefore adjust easier and are able to access better job opportunities. However, they are not free from discrimination and hate crimes.
- Somalis have a more difficult time adjusting because of their limited English speaking ability, tend to be less educated, and some are enrolled into high schools with no previous educational training.
- Trouble adjusting has led some displaced Somali teens to join ethnic gangs in an effort find acceptance and belonging, a problem that the local media often ignores.
- Both Liberians and Somalis feel more comfortable within their own communities and are not quick to trust authority figures. They find the greatest sense of belonging when they are in the company of their own people.



QUESTIONS FOR FURTHUR RESEARCH

1. What can be done to address cultural misunderstanding and resentment toward African immigrants in suburban schools?
2. How has the identity of immigrants been affected by their suburban environments? Do they tend to conform or resist their suburban cultural landscapes?
3. How have suburban schools and districts become segregated? What can be done to improve racial integration?